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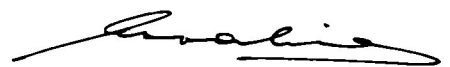
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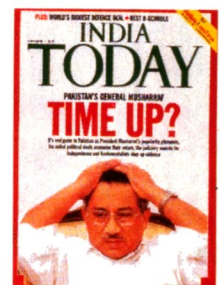
Pakistan President Pervez Musharraf can't stop making news. We have done 15 cover stories on him in the past eight years, making him one of our most featured leaders. In our cover story only two months ago, the headline read: "Time Up?" The story was on the end game in Pakistan with Musharraf's popularity plunging, pressure mounting from political rivals and the judiciary and rising fundamentalist violence. "Time", we said, "was running out and the situation called for desperate, and potentially dangerous, measures." It didn't take long for the end game to reveal itself: survival at any cost. The state of Emergency, a fig leaf for Martial Law, has already followed a familiar and well-worn script used by dictators the world over: the country faces a grave threat, this is the only way to save it from disintegration, it is a purely temporary measure and democracy will be restored once stability returns. The rest of the script follows the same path: suspension of human rights, arrest of political leaders, gagging of the media and the army out in the streets. In a way, he has done a coup on himself. The reasons for the Emergency are actually the promises he had made and should have fulfilled.

Like many Indians and a majority of Pakistanis, I am not surprised at the turn of events. Musharraf, though, was a different kind of military ruler from his predecessors like Ayub Khan and Zia-ul-Haq. He was secular, aligned to the US in the global war on terror which he was aware, would create powerful enemies for him as three assassination attempts proved. Under Musharraf, Pakistan's economy was booming. Finally, despite his double games, he seemed committed to the Indo-Pak peace process. He was willing to look at pragmatic solutions and an unstable Pakistan puts all this in jeopardy.

He now appears like a power-hungry despot and his survival is in serious doubt. Extending his military rule poses the danger of annoying his military commanders and inviting a counter coup. His popularity, at an all-time low before the Emergency, has plummeted further. His political opponents smell blood and the militants in the frontier provinces now pose a serious threat to internal stability. Worse, there is creeping Talibanisation across the country. Given Pakistan's nuclear capability, it is important that the country does not collapse into chaos. The US pressure on him to restore democracy will only add to his woes. The problem is that Musharraf of 1999 is now a pale shadow of his earlier avatar.

Our cover story, from our regular contributor in Karachi and columns from prominent strategic experts, analyses why Musharraf will not last long. It seems the foxy General has run out of his usual tricks as he lacks popular support and accountability. The best-case scenario for him will be to hold a credible general election soon and find an honourable exit route. Regardless, Pakistan's future looks extremely grim. That surely is not good news for India and the world.

  
(Aroon Purie)



Our Sept 2007 cover